Invisible borders and how to find them

Abstract

Any human reality is marked by countless explicit and implicit borders, ranging from state frontiers to the restrictions and conventions defining access within various parts of a house. Moreover, as Barth highlighted more than 50 years ago, borders are the key element in the definition of group identities, as they stand at the core of how individuals perceive themselves and others, and how they conceptualize social spaces inside and outside their communities. However, borders, by definition, are constructs—conceptual fictions that rarely leave tangible traces in archaeological records. So, how can we study borders when they often are inherently invisible?

This contribution examines three recent studies that employ various techniques to render some of the borders characterizing interactions between Egypt and the Levant visible. The first study, by Francesco De Magistris, explored the areas of competence of Egyptian commissioners in the Levant during the Amarna period through the application of what he calls the "proximity principle", successfully revealing the internal borders of the Levantine Egyptian administration. The second study, by the present author, focused on the linguistic affiliation of the names of Levantine rulers in the Amarna period and their correlation with both geographical and socio-historical realities. The results suggested the existence of cultural areas (and thus cultural borders) that played a direct role in the Egyptian geopolitical approach to the region during the 18th dynasty. The final example is provided by the author's ongoing research into the identity frames underlying the description of Levantine foreigners (and consequently the borders inherent in such Egyptian constructs) in New Kingdom Egyptian texts.

These examples will be used to underscore how borders, though inherently invisible, can be uncovered and explored through diverse methods and considerations. The potential to use indirect sociocultural consequences as a proxy for identifying borders will be discussed, as will the utility of multimodal analyses in revealing underlying networks and correlations that could expose them. Emphasizing the importance of recognizing that concepts such as ethnicity and ethnic borders are constructs specific to modern cultures, this contribution will also stress the need to deconstruct these notions, acknowledging that they may not apply or be relevant to ancient societies.

1. Introduction: Borders as Social Constructs

Human experience is invariably shaped by borders. From internationally recognized frontiers to the implicit boundaries governing access to domestic spaces, borders structure social life, regulate individual behaviours, and shape collective identities. Yet their ontological status is inherently paradoxical. Some borders are physically demarcated, while many others are primarily conceptual constructs that lack direct material manifestation and which, therefore, leave little or no trace in the archaeological record. Making sense of these intangible dimensions thus requires theoretical frameworks that could reveal these invisible realities.

Anthropological theory has been particularly influential in this regard, as the conceptualization of borders as dynamic interfaces produced through social interaction and practice has long been a central focus of research, especially in relation to the definition of collective identities. A foundational contribution in this respect is *Ethnic Groups and Boundaries* by Fredrik Barth, which reconceptualized ethnic boundaries as socially maintained processes of differentiation and negotiation rather than as containers of cultural substance.[1] Writing against earlier primordial and culturalist models, Barth argued that ethnic groups persist not because they share an unchanging set of internal traits, but because actors actively mark and reproduce distinctions in situations of interaction. Ethnicity and ethnic borders, in this view, are relational and situational: they emerge at points of contact, where boundaries are maintained through social practices such as marriage rules, economic exchange, political alliance, and symbolic classification. Barth's well-known argument that it is "the ethnic boundary that defines the group, not the cultural stuff that it encloses" redirected scholarly attention from internal cultural traits to the maintenance of boundaries in social interaction.

This reorientation was further developed in more recent studies, such as Rogers Brubaker's critique in *Ethnicity without Groups*, where the author cautions against "groupism", the tendency to treat ethnic groups as internally homogeneous actors rather than to analyse "groupness" as a contingent and variable property of social life.[2]

Building on these approaches, Thomas Hylland Eriksen argues that identity is inherently relational and emerges through processes of contact, comparison, and contrast.[3] Similarly, the development of border studies has emphasized that borders function as pervasive social and political practices rather than as mere territorial edges. Gloria Anzaldúa conceptualized borderlands as lived spaces of hybridity and negotiation,[4] while Étienne Balibar argued that borders are dispersed throughout social and political life and operate as mechanisms of inclusion and exclusion.[5]

These theoretical developments have significant implications for archaeology and ancient history. The point is that while state frontiers occasionally leave architectural or inscriptional traces in the archaeological record, most geographical, geopolitical, and sociocultural borders, do not. A mountain range or river valley, for example, could serve as a natural feature of the landscape while simultaneously functioning as an administrative limit and, over time, as a marker of sociocultural and identity differentiation between those considered "inside" and "outside" the spaces they delimit. Yet, while the geographical feature (mountain, river, etc) embodying the border survive through time, the actual border as a negotiated convention among communities has no distinctive materiality and therefore it can be expected to be archaeologically invisible.

But if borders rarely leave clear material traces, how can they be examined in a systematic way? The answer lies, I believe, in the fact that, as said, *all* borders are primarily stemming from and reflected in practice: in the administrative reach of a state, in the writing choices of a scribe, in the jurisdiction exercised by an official, or in the classificatory language used to talk

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[1] Fredrik Barth, ed., *Ethnic Groups and Boundaries: The Social Organization of Culture Difference* (Little, Brown and Co., 1969).
[2] Rogers Brubaker, *Ethnicity without Groups*, 1. Harvard Univ. Press paperback ed (Harvard University Press, 2006).
[3] Thomas Hylland Eriksen, ed., *Ethnicity and Nationalism: Anthropological Perspectives*, 3rd ed, Anthropology, Culture, and Society (Pluto Press, 2010).
[4] Gloria Anzalduá, *Borderlands: The New Mestiza = La Frontera*, 1. ed (Aunt Lute Books, 1991).
[5] Étienne Balibar, *Politics and the Other Scene*, Phronesis (Verso, 2002).

about “us” and the “others”. As a result, we need methodological approaches that move away from the search of an (illusory?) materiality of borders, and which rely instead on sociocultural proxies and multimodal datasets to reconstruct intangible structures of differentiation. Specifically, we can say that in order to trace how past societies defined, negotiated, and experienced boundaries, the analysis must look for patterns, clusters, and points of disruption across multiple contexts and types of evidence, rather than focusing exclusively on physical markers.

To illustrate how such an “archaeology of the invisible” might operate in practice, and how intangible borders can be reconstructed through it, this contribution presents three case studies addressing different aspects of the Levantine–Egyptian interface during the Late Bronze Age:

Case Study I. Building on the “proximity principle” proposed by Francesco De Magistris, this section analyses the activities of Egyptian commissioners in the Levant in order to map an implicit grid of geopolitical authority defined by jurisdictional mandate and communicative networks rather than by fixed territorial frontiers.

Case Study II. This analysis examines the linguistic affiliations of rulers’ names in the Amarna correspondence as proxies for identifying cultural borderlands and patterns across the Levant.

Case Study III. The final case study investigates Egyptian textual identity frames, ranging from geopolitical designations to sociocultural stereotypes, through which conceptual borders were constructed between the Egyptian Self and the foreign Other.

Together, these case studies illustrate that invisible borders can be reconstructed through careful correlation of administrative practice, linguistic evidence, and ideological discourse. By combining theoretical reflection with empirical analysis, it becomes possible to move beyond the search for material boundary markers and toward a relational understanding of how ancient societies conceptualized and enacted differentiation.

2.1 Administrative Borders and the “Proximity Principle”

The political order of the Late Bronze Age Levant was structured by networks of vassalage and imperial administration, particularly under the aegis of Egypt’s Eighteenth Dynasty. The principal source for this political landscape is the Amarna letter corpus, discovered at Tell el-Amarna. These clay tablets, written in Akkadian cuneiform, consist largely of correspondence between the Egyptian court and rulers of Levantine city states. They document diplomatic exchanges, requests for military aid, accusations against neighbouring rulers, and negotiations between the pharaoh and local elites. Although the letters were not composed to provide systematic geographical or administrative descriptions, they constitute one of the richest bodies of evidence for interstate relations in the Late Bronze Age eastern Mediterranean.[6]

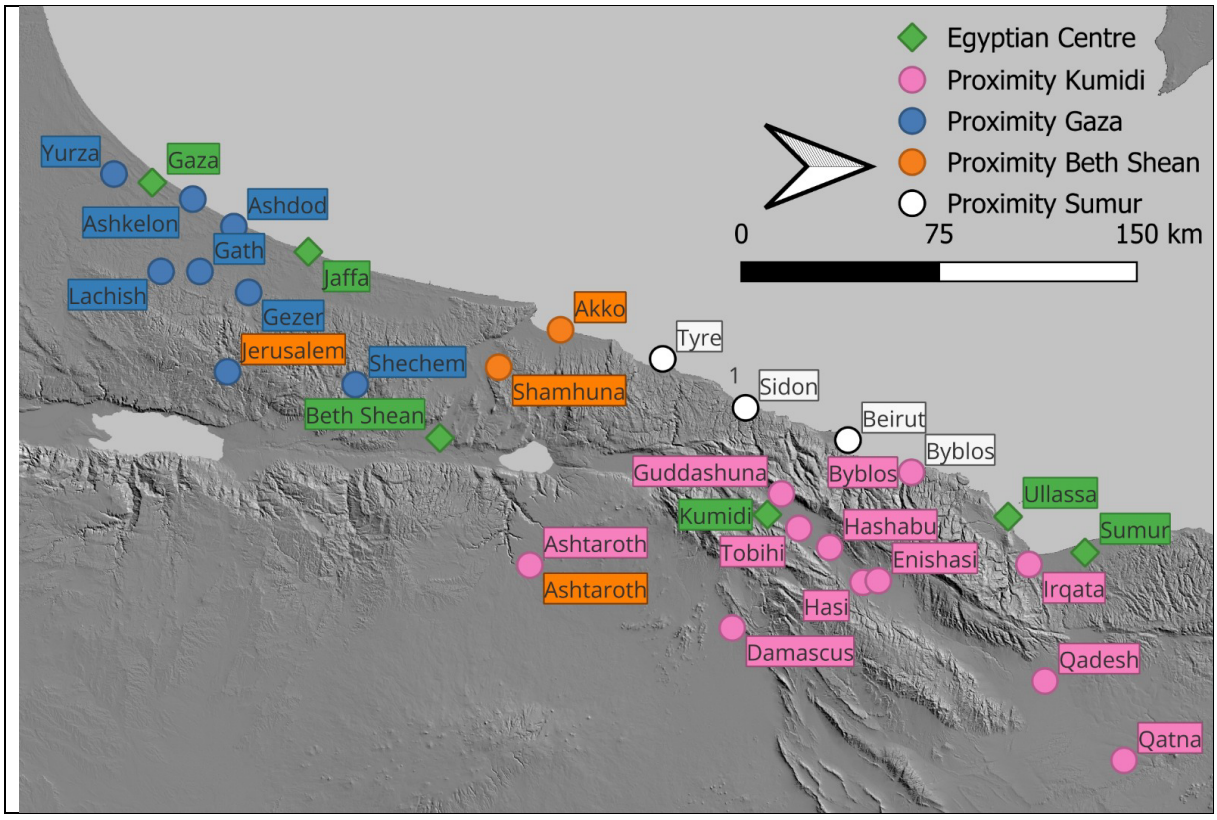
Administrative borders, understood here as implicit divisions of territorial responsibility and managerial competence, are especially difficult to identify in this corpus. Unlike the Nile Valley, where provincial divisions are more clearly attested, Egyptian governance in the Levant operated through appointed officials commonly designated in modern scholarship as commissioners. These figures acted as intermediaries between the pharaoh and local rulers. The Amarna letters frequently mention such officials, sometimes appealing to their authority,

[6] William L. Moran, *The Amarna Letters* (Johns Hopkins University Press, 1992).

sometimes criticizing their conduct, and occasionally reporting violent incidents. For example, Amarna letter EA 362 refers to the killing of an Egyptian commissioner by local actors.

Building on this textual record, De Magistris has proposed a methodological approach to identify the borders of the areas administered by these commissioners; he calls this approach the Proximity Principle.[7] The Proximity Principle rests on an empirical assumption: Levantine rulers were most likely to address the Egyptian commissioner who was geographically closest to them. By systematically analyse patterns of correspondence between city states and named commissioners in the Amarna corpus together with petrographic data about the origin of the clay used in the tablets sent by various rulers, De Magistris reconstructs spheres of administrative interaction. These spheres effectively delineate zones of influence, not through fixed territorial boundaries, but through recurring relational ties.

The significance of the Proximity Principle lies in its capacity to recover spatial organization from relational data. For decades, scholars have debated the number and location of Egyptian administrative centres in the Levant and the extent of their authority. De Magistris' analysis suggests that connectivity patterns, specifically who corresponded with whom and with what frequency, can serve as proxies for administrative centrality and jurisdictional reach. In a context where communication depended on physical travel, it is reasonable to assume that messengers would ordinarily interact with the nearest available authority. Statistical clusters of correspondence therefore generate an implicit map of administrative fields (figure 1). Functional borders emerge not as inscribed lines but as patterned gradients of interaction.



[7] Francesco I. De Magistris, 'Yarimuta as the Yarkon River Valley', *Ägypten Und Levante / Egypt and the Levant* 30 (2020): 301–11; Francesco I. De Magistris, 'A Tale of Two Cities: Ṣumur and Kumidi as Egyptian Centres in the Late 18 th Dynasty', *Altorientalische Forschungen* 50, no. 2 (2023): 150–69; Francesco I. De Magistris, 'The Proximity Principle and the Egyptian Levant in the Late 18th Dynasty', *Bulletin of ASOR* 391 (2024): 77–92.

Figure 1 – Map of the areas of competence of the various Egyptian centres according to De Magistris Proximity Principle (from De Magistris, in preparation).

In the Egyptian Levant, administrative borders are thus better conceived as zones of operational competence radiating from nodal centres. Interestingly, it can be shown that these zones could change over time in response to the developments of the broader geopolitical landscape. For instance, De Magistris shows that the Egyptian imperial administration moved one of its centres from Ṣumur in the Akkar Plain to Kumidi in the Beqa Valley toward the end of the Amarna period, likely in response to the deteriorating geopolitical conditions in those northern border regions.[8] Moreover, the present author has suggested that Ṣumur may have assumed administrative functions previously held by Byblos following the campaigns of Thutmose III, potentially in response to the establishment of peace with Mitanni at the end of his reign or during the early years of his successor, Amenhotep II.[9]

Two broader theoretical implications follow. First, administrative borders in ancient imperial systems are more usefully understood as operational rather than territorial. They delineated spheres of authority, responsibility, and jurisdiction, not sovereignty over clearly bounded space in the modern sense. What mattered was who answered to whom, who transmitted information to whom, and who exercised competence in a given context, rather than control over a precisely delimited territory.

Second, such borders become visible only when the primary evidence is approached relationally. Patterns of communication, frequency of contact, and configurations of allegiance must be analysed as interconnected data rather than as isolated attestations. When examined in this way, they allow us to reconstruct administrative geographies as they functioned in practice, through networks of authority and interaction. This approach thus resonates with broader developments in historical network analysis, which emphasize the reconstruction of political and social structures through patterns of interaction rather than through explicit territorial demarcations.

As a result, although the Egyptians did not leave boundary markers separating one commissioner's area of responsibility from another's, the Proximity Principle makes it possible to infer these spheres from the structure of the surviving correspondence.

2.2. Onomastics and Cultural Borders in the Amarna Period

A second avenue for identifying invisible cultural borders in the Late Bronze Age Levant lies in the study of personal names, and was pursued by the present author in two related studies.[10] The idea is straightforward: onomastic evidence provides insight into linguistic, cultural, and political affiliations that are not always visible in the archaeological or textual record. Consequently, by examining the linguistic affiliations of personal names and mapping their

[8] De Magistris, 'A Tale of Two Cities'.
[9] Marwan Kilani, *Byblos in the Late Bronze Age: Interactions between the Levantine and Egyptian Worlds*, Studies in the Archaeology and History of the Levant 9 (Brill, 2019).
[10] Marwan Kilani, 'Sociolinguistic Identities and Egyptian Imperialism in the Early Late Bronze Age Levant.', *Journal of Ancient Egyptian Interconnections* 28 (2020): 47–64; Marwan Kilani, 'Naming Practices and Identity in the Early Late Bronze Age Levant: A Linguistic and Geographical Analysis of Local Rulers' Names Attested in the Amarna Letters', *Journal of Ancient Egyptian Interconnections* 27 (2020): 70–93; see also Richard S. Hess, 'Cultural Aspects of Onomastic Distribution in the Amarna Texts', *Ugarit-Forschungen* 21 (1989): 209–16 who first observed the presence of patterns in the geographical distribution of these names.

geographical distribution, we can identify patterns of cultural differentiation and thus cultural borders across a region.

The test-case I selected was provided by the corpora of names of rulers attested in the Amarna correspondence (who bear names drawn from diverse linguistic traditions including Northwest Semitic, Hurrian, Indo-Aryan, and others). The analysis clearly showed the presence of onomastic clusters where names stemming from the same linguistic traditions concentrated in geographically coherent zones rather than being random distributions (Figure 2). In turn, the fact that rulers with names reflecting similar linguistic traditions tend to concentrate in specific areas suggests the existence of stable regional naming practices that predate and potentially inform interactions with the Egyptian court. In this sense, onomastic zones function as proxies for broader sociolinguistic landscapes, indicating networks of interaction, shared conventions, and spheres of influence within the Levant.

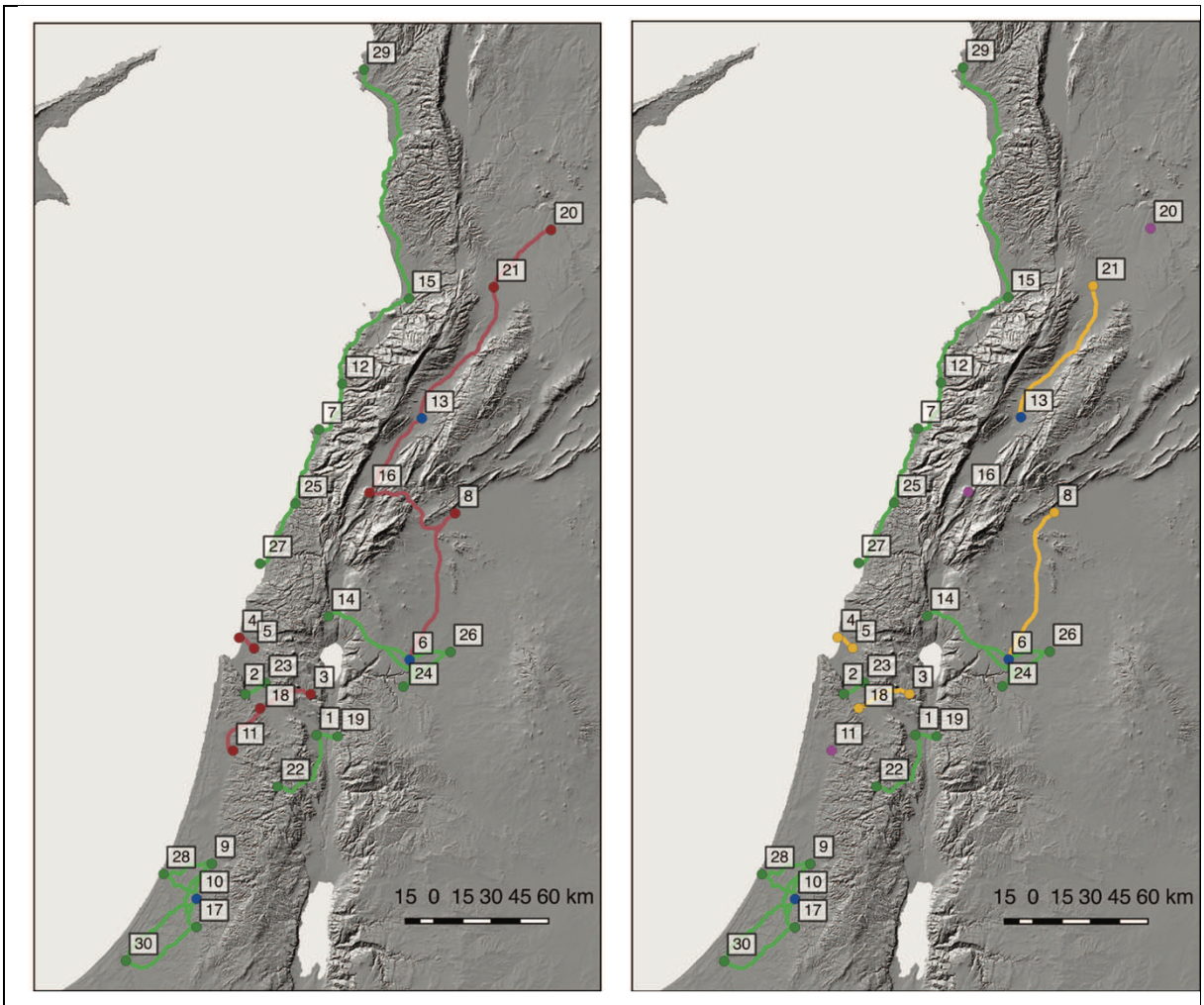


Figure 2 - Distribution of names of rulers belonging to different linguistic traditions in the Amarna corpus (Kilani 2020a). On the left, clusters of cities are shown with rulers bearing West Semitic names (green) and non-West Semitic names (red). Blue dots mark cities where rulers with both West Semitic and non-West Semitic names are attested. On the right, clusters of cities with rulers bearing West Semitic names (green) and Indo-Aryan names (yellow) are displayed. No clusters of Hurrian names (pink) are identifiable. Blue dots indicate cities where rulers with both West Semitic and Indo-Aryan names are attested. For details on the identification of the cities, see Table 1 in Kilani 2020a.

Interestingly, the evidence further indicates that these sociolinguistic zones are meaningfully correlated with Egyptian imperial engagement.[11] Specifically, when we compare the distribution of names belonging to West Semitic versus non-West Semitic linguistic traditions with the trajectories of Egyptian military and administrative activity under Thutmose III and Amenhotep II, a clear correlation emerges: Egyptian campaigns were concentrated in regions where rulers bore non-Northwest Semitic names. It thus appears that regions which, in the Amarna period, were characterized by local rulers sharing particular linguistic traditions had experienced similar forms of interaction with Egyptian military power a few generations earlier, during the reign of Thutmose III. In particular, some areas, typically those with Northwest Semitic names, experienced less direct military activity, whereas regions ruled by non-Northwest Semitic leaders underwent more intense actively military interactions.

From these observations we can also infer that Egyptian policy did not simply superimpose a hegemonic template onto a cultural blank slate but operated in dialogue with the complex sociolinguistic realities of the Levant. Different cultural regions responded in distinct ways: regions governed by rulers with Northwest Semitic names may have been more inclined to peacefully align with or even support Egyptian military interventions, whereas regions ruled by leaders with non-Northwest Semitic names often exhibited resistance or active antagonism. Egyptian strategies, therefore, appear to have been pragmatically adapted to these local contexts.

It is important to stress that linguistic affiliation in personal names should not be equated with ethnicity in the modern sense. Names functioned within overlapping social, political, and diplomatic frameworks. They could signify allegiance to a political entity, alignment with elite networks, aspirational prestige, or strategic self-fashioning under different macro-regional overlords. A ruler might adopt a name from a prominent linguistic or cultural tradition to assert loyalty or legitimacy, or it could retain local name to mark autonomy or cultural continuity in the eyes of his own subjects.

A diachronic perspective reveals additional fluidity. While the distribution of names in the Amarna corpus reflects broader geopolitical patterns consistent with general stability, there are also cases in which successive rulers bear names drawn from linguistic traditions different from those of their predecessors. The kingdom of Amurru provides a clear illustration of this phenomenon. Under Egyptian influence, Amurru's rulers predominantly carried Northwest Semitic names. After Amurru became a Hittite vassal, the ruling dynasty adopted primarily Hurrian names.[12] It is difficult to determine whether this shift was intended as a political statement, to mark a rupture between the dynasty's previous history under Egyptian rule and its new status as a Hittite vassal, to demonstrate the loyalty of Amurru's rulers to their Hittite overlords by adopting names prestigious within the Hittite imperial sphere, or if it simply reflected concrete cultural influence from a Hurrian linguistic tradition following their integration into the Hittite empire. What is clear, however, is that this onomastic shift demonstrates that naming practices were sensitive to changing political realities and could reflect evolving geopolitical alignments.

This case illustrates that onomastic zones reflect dynamic sociocultural realities, and that shifts in naming practices can correlate with, and perhaps even reveal, changes in geopolitical affiliations and the boundaries of imperial spheres of influence. At the same time, it is important to emphasize that onomastic clusters do not necessarily represent fixed identities or

[11] Kilani, 'Sociolinguistic Identities and Egyptian Imperialism'.
[12] Itamar Singer, 'A Political History of Ugarit', in *Handbook of Ugaritic Studies*, ed. Wilfred G. E. Watson and Nick Wyatt, Handbuch Der Orientalistik. Erste Abteilung, Nahe Und Der Mittlere Osten 39 (Brill, 1999), 159.

ethnicities. Rather, they should be understood as indicators of shared practices, affiliations, and social imaginaries that structured interaction at multiple scales, from local networks of authority to transregional imperial negotiation. From this perspective, onomastic analysis provides a powerful tool for visualizing the subtler contours of Late Bronze Age cultural landscapes. By mapping name distributions and examining patterns of variation and continuity, and by looking at how their distribution evolved over time, we can reconstruct how identity, affiliation, and prestige intersected with political power, and where the borders of these social and geopolitical realities were located.

2.3. Identity Frames and Conceptual Borders in New Kingdom Texts

In recent decades, ethnicity has often been treated as a primary framework for understanding collective identities in Egyptology and archaeology in general,[13] usually based on the implicit assumption that it is a universal feature of all human societies. This assumption, however, is misleading.

Specialized scholarship has long shown that ethnicity is not an objective, universal reality but a cultural construct based on social borders defined on real or imagined differences in origin or ancestry, language, religion, or other cultural features and traditions.[14] As such, its role, salience, and even presence vary significantly across societies. In some societies ethnicity provides the primary framework for their collective identities, while others organize their collective identities around other sociocultural factors, such as kinship, locality, or castes and other social hierarchies. Moreover, some societies employ ethnicity to define themselves, others employ it only primarily as a projected framework to categorize outsiders, while in yet some other "ethnic-indifferent" societies the very concept of ethnicity is virtually absent.[15]

In my ongoing research, I argue that Egyptian royal sources from the New Kingdom (such as the Annals of Thutmose III, the inscriptions of Qadesh or Ramses II, or the records of the wars of Merenptah and Ramses III) provide an intriguing example of an ethnic-indifferent society, or at least of an ethnic-indifferent framework of representing and classifying others (see Kilani 2023, 130–31 for a first introduction of the idea, which is being further developed in an article in preparation). These sources frequently mention Levantine individuals and groups, but careful analysis shows that rather than employing abstract notions of ethnicity, the Egyptians categorized foreign populations according to political allegiance, geographic origin,

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[13] see e.g. Christina Riggs and John Baines, 'Ethnicity', *UCLA Encyclopedia of Egyptology (Online)* 1, no. 1 (2012): 1, https://escholarship.org/uc/item/32r9x0jr#author; Uroš Matić, *Ethnic Identities in the Land of the Pharaohs: Past and Present Approaches in Egyptology*, Elements Ancient Egypt in Context (Cambridge University Press, 2020) for general overviews.

[14] Barth, *Ethnic Groups and Boundaries*; Rogers Brubaker, *Ethnicity without Groups* (Harvard University Press, 2006); Max Weber, *Economy and Society: A New Translation*, trans. Keith Tribe (Harvard University Press, 2019), 389; Donald L. Horowitz, *Ethnic Groups in Conflict* (Univ. of California Press, 1985); Pierre Louis Van den Berghe, *The Ethnic Phenomenon* (Elsevier, 1982); Kanchan Chandra and Steven Wilkinson, 'Measuring the Effect of "Ethnicity"', *Comparative Political Studies* 41, nos 4–5 (2008): 515–63; Eriksen, *Ethnicity and Nationalism*; Felix Stein and Sara Shneiderman, 'Ethnicity', *Cambridge Encyclopedia of Anthropology*, ahead of print, 2022.

[15] see e.g. Marc Helbling and Nenad Stojanović, 'Switzerland: Challenging the Big Theories of Nationalism', *Nations and Nationalism* 17, no. 4 (2011): 712–17; Petra Burzová, *Okouzleni pohledem na dav: principy uzavření a meze postsocialistické slovenské identifikace*, Vydání první (Sociologické nakladatelství (SLON), 2014); Marek Jakoubek, 'Ethnic Indifference – Fredrik Barth's Conceptual Blind Spot', *Anthropological Notebooks* 25, no. 1 (2019): 1; Christa Uehlinger and Stefan Kammhuber, 'Managing Cultural Diversity in Switzerland', in *Handbook of Diversity Competence: European Perspectives*, ed. Petia Genkova et al. (Springer Nature Switzerland, 2025).

and social function. This suggests that Egyptian conceptions of foreign identity, at least as represented in royal records, were largely geopolitical and sociopolitical rather than ethnic.

Two principal types of identity frames can be distinguished in the New Kingdom sources: those I term "People of Place or Country X" and "People-X." The first frame organizes individuals in relation to a recognized polity or territory, while the second encompasses groups that fall outside the established geopolitical system, often marked by functional, social, or behavioural characteristics.

2.3.1 The Geopolitical Framework: "People of Place/Country X"

The primary and most common pattern found across New Kingdom texts is the use of *demonyms* and *demonymic* expressions, i.e. labels that define groups in relation to territorial and political entities, as "People of Place/Country X".[16] These labels appear in Egyptian sources either as true demonyms (gentilic/nisba forms) or, more frequently, as periphrastic constructions identifying people through their relation to specific geographical regions or geopolitical entities. For example, the term *qd(y)w* : "Qodians" (Annals of Thutmose III, Urk IV 649:10) identifies the inhabitants of the region of *qd* : Qode, while formulae such as *ḫrw pf [ḥs] n qdš* : 'that [wicked] foe of Qadesh' (Annals of Thutmose III, Urk IV 649:5), *wr.w nb.w rmnn* : 'all the rulers of Lebanon" (Thutmose III's Gebel Barkal Stela, Urk IV 1242:2) or *rmṯ tꜣ ḫtꜣ* : 'people(s) of the land of Hatti" (Qadesh Inscriptions of Ramses II, KRI II 252:1) define people as rulers or subjects of specific regions or geopolitical entities (kingdoms, countries, etc.). The central feature of this framework is that populations are defined by their relationship with place or geopolitical entities, not by culture or ancestry, and this geopolitical frame is dominant in New Kingdom royal inscriptions and administrative texts.

These geopolitical affiliations were not static in the Egyptian conceptualization of the world but shifted in response to changing conditions on the ground. The city-state of Tunip, located along the Orontes River in what is now western Syria, provides a useful case study for how Egyptian scribes "re-bordered" foreign populations according to imperial fluctuations. Tunip is well attested in Egyptian records from the time of Thutmose III through the reigns of Ramesses II and Ramesses III as a political actor located between Egypt, Mitanni, and Hatti.[17]

In particular, in the Annals of Thutmose III, Tunip appears as an autonomous city-state that resisted Egyptian hegemony. Here we find expressions such as *ḫrw pf n tnp* : 'that foe of Tunip' (Annals of Thutmose III, Urk IV 686:3), where the ruler of Tunip is singled out as an independent "foe" of Egypt. By the time of Ramesses III, however, the geopolitical landscape had shifted markedly owing to Hittite expansion in the north. Following the Battle of Kadesh during the reign of Ramses II and subsequent treaties, the Orontes Valley, including Tunip, came within the Hittite sphere of influence. Egyptian records reflect this transformation in their identity frames. In the inscriptions of Ramesses III at Medinet Habu, there is no mention anymore of an independent ruler of Tunip and the city is referred to as *tnp n ḫtꜣ* : 'Tunip of Hatti' (KRI V 78:15), indicating a reconceptualization of the city's position relative to the new imperial reconfiguration of the region. This shift in boundary was not driven by demographic replacement or cultural assimilation but by political realignment.[18] To the

[16] On these terms, see Paul Dickson, *What Do You Call a Person from ...? A Dictionary of Resident Names* (Facts on File, 1990).
[17] Donald B. Redford, 'The Northern Wars of Thutmose III', in *Thutmose III: A New Biography*, ed. Eric H. Cline and David O'Connor (University of Michigan Press, 2006); Moran, *The Amarna Letters*.
[18] Marwan Kilani, '*tj-nꜣ-y* and *kft(j)w* in the Annals of Thutmose III: a reassessment of Urk. IV 733:4–7', *Ägypten und Levante* 32 (2023): 130–31.

Egyptian scribes, the identity of Tunip had changed because its political overlord had changed. In this context, the conceptual border moved from distinguishing Tunip as an independent other to situating it within the Hittite geopolitical sphere.

This pattern reflects the administrative logic of Egyptian imperialism in the Levant. Egypt's dominance was exercised over a mosaic of autonomous and semi-autonomous city-states rather than over territorially unified, ethnically homogeneous populations. Egyptian interaction with Levantine polities centered on regional diplomatic, tributary, and military relations rather than on attempts to interact with, or impose, ethnically defined identities upon local populations.[19] The pharaoh's relations with Levantine rulers therefore operated within a geopolitical logic that privileged territorial control, geopolitical affiliations, and strategic alliances. This emphasis is consistent with broader interpretations of New Kingdom foreign relations, which see Egyptian policy as reactive and negotiated rather than driven by ideologies of ethnic taxonomy.

Such geopolitical classifications was not limited to Egypt, but can be recognized also in the contemporary Levant.[20] There, it manifests clearly, for instance, through the so-called household metaphor , which was employed in international correspondence to articulate both horizontal and vertical relationships among various political actors, including kings, vassals, and overlords, in terms of hierarchical position within a conceptual international family, with, for instance, rulers of equal rank addressed one another as 'brothers', while referring to their hierarchical superiors as 'fathers' or 'master', or to themselves as 'sons' or 'servants'.[21] This metaphor permeates the language of literary and administrative documents, situating foreign populations within a recognized, ethnic-indifferent structural grid of authority which embedded political relations within a familial idiom that rendered hierarchy intelligible and normative.

The categorization of peoples according to their political affiliation or territorial belonging thus served as the primary means of ideological structuring of contemporary polities and imperial worldview, both in Egypt and in the Levant. Ethnicity, as a construct rooted in self-ascribed real or imagined common ancestry or cultural heritage, does not feature as a primary criterion in these frameworks.

2.3.2 The Projected Sociocultural Framework: "People-X"

Not all Levantine groups could be easily identified in association with a specific geographical or geopolitical entity. For populations that fell outside the structured imperial framework, such as outcasts, semi nomads, or itinerant marauders, the Egyptians employed what can be termed "People X" labels. At first glance, some of these terms might appear ethnic in nature; however, careful analysis reveals a more complex reality. While a few terms may derive from actual tribal or regional names, the majority functioned either as Egyptian-projected stereotypes or as labels reflecting social or occupational roles. Terms of Egyptian origin, such

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[19] see e.g. Raymond Cohen and Raymond Westbrook, eds, *Amarna Diplomacy: The Beginnings of International Relations* (Johns Hopkins University Press, 2000); Mario Liverani, *International Relations in the Ancient Near East, 1600–1100 BC*, Studies in Diplomacy (Palgrave, 2001).

[20] see Jana Mynářová, 'Liminal People(s) in the Late Bronze Age Levant? A New Light on Sherden (*Šerdanu*)', *Journal of Ancient Near Eastern History* 9, no. 2 (2022): 285–304 for a recent discussion.

[21] J. David Schloen, *The House of the Father As Fact and Symbol: Patrimonialism in Ugarit and the Ancient Near East* (Brill, 2001), 255–316; see recently on this concept in Egyptian sources Gaëlle Chantrain, ' "Like a Son to Me": The Household Metaphor as Marker of Hierarchical Relationships between Egyptians and Foreigners in Egyptian Tales', paper presented at international conference Crossroads IV – Migration and Mobility in the Ancient Near East and Egypt, 2022.

as *šꜣs.w* : ‘the wanderers’, likely derive from the verb *šꜣs* : ‘to travel, wander’ and reveal the Egyptian perception of a behaviour considered distinctive enough to mark these populations as different. Others, like *ḥrʸ-šʿ* : ‘those on the sand’, demonstrate continuity from pre-New Kingdom texts, revealing a long-standing tradition of stereotypization.

Egyptian scribes also adopted designations from other languages, most of which appear to have functioned as occupational or social labels. The term Hapiru (Egyptian *ʿp.rw*) provides a paradigmatic example. Across the Ancient Near East, “Hapiru” did not denote a specific ethnicity, tribe, or linguistic group but rather a liminal social class of displaced persons, fugitives, outcasts, or migrant labourers who had severed ties with their original urban or rural communities.[22] Their identity was defined by their way of living on the margins of the state. Because they lacked a fixed geopolitical “home”, they were often seen by the Egyptian administration as a source of both instability and labour, appearing in texts as bandits or, alternatively, as captive workers.

The biography of Idrimi of Alalakh[23] provides the clearest evidence that Hapiru status was a reversible social category rather than a fixed ethnic identity. Idrimi, a prince of Aleppo, recounts fleeing a coup and spending several years living among the Hapiru in Canaan. During this period, he adopted their stateless lifestyle, which demonstrates social mobility within this designation, and which suggests that the Hapiru were a heterogeneous assembly of diverse individuals sharing a social condition rather than a common ancestry. However, once Idrimi reclaimed his throne in Alalakh, he ceased to be Hapiru, confirming that the distinction between “regular” subjects and the Hapiru was sociopolitical rather than ethnic.

The term *ḫꜣ-rw*, generally translated as “Hurrian,” may be classified similarly. While frequently assumed to signify ethnicity, its use in Egyptian sources was more nuanced. Egyptian scribes first employ the term in the 18th Dynasty to describe a Levantine community distinguished from West Semitic populations. However, Hurrian identity in the Near East was often a projected category, not a self-ascribed ethnos: to my knowledge, there is no attestation of individuals describing themselves as being “Hurrian” in any near eastern sources. Rather, the term is primarily used to define regions, e.g. ‘country of Hurru’ = ‘Mitanni’[24]. In this respect, the adjective *ḫurlili*, used in Hittite texts to denote the Hurrian language, is particularly revealing. Linguistically, it can be analysed as an adjective in *-li* derived from a demonym in *-la-* based on the place name *ḫur-*. This indicates that the phrase does not mean “the language of the Hurrians” in an ethnic sense, but rather “the language of the inhabitants of the land of Hurru”, emphasizing a territorial rather than ethnic Hittite understanding of this term.[25] Finally, the use in Hittite documents (e.g. KBo 3.46, 3.60) and in the Amarna letters (EA 60) of the expression ‘king of the Hurrian troops’ to refer to the Mitannian king raises

[22] Mario Liverani, ‘Il Fuoriuscitismo in Siria Nella Tarda Età Del Bronzo’, *Rivista Storica Italiana* 88 (1965); Mario Liverani, ‘Farsi Habiru’, *Vicino Oriente* 2 (1978): 65–77; Oswald Loretz, *Habiru-Hebräer: eine sozio-linguistische Studie über die Herkunft des Gentiliziums ʿibrî vom Appellativum ḫabiru*, Beihefte zur Zeitschrift für die alttestamentliche Wissenschaft 160 (De Gruyter, 1984); Michael C. Astour, ‘The Ḫapiru in the Amarna Texts. Basic Points of Controversy’, *Ugarit-Forschungen* 31 (1999): 31–50; Ann E. Killebrew, ‘Hybridity, Hapiru, and the Archaeology of Ethnicity in Second Millennium Bce Western Asia’, in *A Companion to Ethnicity in the Ancient Mediterranean*, 1st edn, ed. Jeremy McInerney (Wiley, 2014).
[23] Jacob Lauinger, *Labors of Idrimi: Inscribing the Past, Shaping the Present at Late Bronze Age Alalah*, Ancient Near East Monographs 33 (SBL Press, 2024).
[24] Emmanuel Laroche, *Glossaire de la langue hourrite*, Études et commentaires 93 (Klincksieck, 1980), 115.
[25] Gernot Wilhelm, ‘Hurrian’, in *The Ancient Languages of Asia Minor*, 1st edn, ed. Roger D. Woodard (Cambridge University Press, 2008), 95.

questions about whether this term designated a population or a (geographically specific?) military class.

At any rate, for what concerns the Egyptian sources, by the Ramesside period, the term underwent topographical fossilization.[26] In these later texts the terms has clearly lost any connection to a specific group and had become a purely geographic designation encompassing Western Syria the Levantine coast, and could even be used as a term to describe the Mediterranean Sea, as attested by the tale of Wenamun, where we find the expression *pꜣ y-mʷ ꜣ n ḫꜣ-rʷ* : 'the great sea of *ḫꜣ-rʷ*' (Wen. 1.49).

Finally, a particularly fertile source for the study of non-ethnic "People-X" labels is the lexicon of military groups and mercenaries. In the Late Bronze Age Levant, terms such as *mryn = maryannu* : 'a class of chariot-warriors'[27] and *nʿrn* : "elite young troops"[28] frequently appear in administrative and historical Egyptian texts. While modern scholars occasionally attempt to link these terms to specific ethnolinguistic or ethnic strata (such as Indo-Aryan for the *maryannu*) their primary function in the sources is descriptive of social or military class rather than ethnicity.[29]

Recent scholarship on the *šrdn* : 'Sherden' demonstrates this principle. Jana Mynářová[30] emphasizes that in the Amarna letters, the term lacks ethnic connotation; rather, it designates specialized military units integrated into Egyptian and Levantine administrative systems. Mynářová proposes that the term may derive etymologically from a Hittite term describing a military category. This reassessment highlights that what is often interpreted as the "arrival of a new people" may in fact be the adoption of a new military designation.

The *plst* : 'Peleset' offer another illustration. Traditionally regarded as the ancestors of the Philistines, an Iron Age populations, the Peleset in New Kingdom texts appear primarily as mariners and warriors within a maritime confederation. As I will argue in a paper currently in preparation, the contexts in which they are mentioned emphasizes functional roles rather than self-ascribed tribal or ethnic identity. Thus, following this "military-origin" hypothesis, the Peleset label may initially have denoted a type of marauder or mercenary group, which subsequently crystallized into a settled ethno-national polity through processes of ethnogenesis. In this respect, the Greek term παλαιστής *palaistḗs* = 'fighter', 'wrestler', which has been compared to the name of the Philistines,[31] might not be only a later Greek pun, but might perhaps provide a suggestive clue about a deeper etymological origin for the name.

The *ṯkr* = 'Tjeker' demonstrate a parallel trajectory. In the reliefs of Ramesses III at Medinet Habu, they are depicted as specialized maritime warriors, analogous to the Peleset, suggesting that Egyptians categorized them as a professional or functional group rather than an ethnic population. However, by the time of the Report of Wenamun in the late 20th Dynasty, the

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[26] Pascal Vernus, 'Les Hurrites dans les sources égyptiennes', in *Problèmes concernant les Hurrites*, ed. Marie Thérèse Barrelet, Mémoire 49 (Éditions Recherche sur les civilisations, 1984).
[27] Eva von Dassow, 'Maryanni', in *The Encyclopedia of Ancient History*, online, ed. Roger S. Bagnall et al. (John Wiley & Sons, 2015).
[28] Marwan Kilani, 'On the Vocalization of Semitic Words in Late Bronze Age Egyptian Transcriptions: New Evidence from Papyrus Anastasi I', in *To Gaul, to Greece and into Noah's Ark: Essays in Honour of Kevin J. Cathcart on the Occasion of His Eightieth Birthday*, ed. Laura Quick et al., Journal of Semitic Studies Supplement 44 (Oxford University Press, 2019).
[29] Dassow, 'Maryanni'.
[30] 'Liminal People(s) in the Late Bronze Age Levant?'
[31] David M. Jacobson, 'Palestine and Israel', *Bulletin of the American Schools of Oriental Research* 313 (1999): 65–74.

Tjeker are firmly associated with the city of Dor on the Levantine coast. This illustrates the transformation from mobile, functionally defined groups into territorially anchored, possibly proto-national communities as Egyptian imperial infrastructure receded from the region.

It is important to observe that these trajectories are not unique to the ancient Near East or to the New Kingdom. Several historical parallels demonstrate how the "invisible border" of a professional or social category can eventually crystallize into a distinct and enduring community identity. These parallels provide a useful lens for understanding how groups such as the Peleset or Tjeker could transition from specialized maritime units to settled regional polities.

A clear example is provided by the Janissaries of the Ottoman Empire. Originally, "Janissary" (Yeniçeri) was a functional designation for an elite infantry corps recruited through the devshirme system from diverse Christian Balkan backgrounds. The Janissaries constituted a "community of practice", defined by rigorous training, a specific dress code, and a shared martial lifestyle that deliberately severed original kin ties. Although they remained a military caste for centuries, in certain border regions, most notably in the Eyalet of Bosnia, their distinct social status and corporate identity began to take on hereditary qualities. This process created a social block that was separate from both the local peasantry and the central Turkish elite, illustrating how a state-imposed functional category could evolve into a self-perpetuating community identity.[32]

Similarly, the Mamluks of Egypt and Syria represent a sociopolitical category maintained through a pseudo-kinship system. Although the term literally means "owned", the Mamluks formed a powerful military aristocracy, primarily of Turkic and Caucasian origin. They preserved their group boundaries through a specific lifestyle of slave-soldier training and restrictive marriage patterns that prioritized the military household over biological ancestry. For centuries, being a Mamluk was a functional identity that overrode birth origins, creating a conceptual boundary between the ruling military elite and the native population.[33]

The Vikings provide another interesting example. Modern scholarship has clarified that "viking" was initially not a collective name for a people but rather a professional descriptor for an activity (*að fara í víking* : 'to go on an expedition'). Viking crews were often heterogeneous and drawn from multiple communities, unified primarily by the practice of maritime raiding and trade. It was only later, through the eyes of their victims and subsequent later myth-making, that this professional activity became reified as the identity of the "Viking people" a collective category that the participants themselves would likely not have recognized in the eighth or ninth centuries.[34]

Finally, the Cossacks of the early modern period provide a clear example where these processes led to the emergence of a contemporary ethnic group. Initially, "Cossack" did not denote a specific community of origin but rather a social class of semi-autonomous, militarized frontiersmen of diverse backgrounds, including Slavic, Tatar, and other groups. They shared a distinctive lifestyle and military function on the edges of the Polish-Lithuanian and Russian states. Over successive generations, through permanent settlement in the steppe and the creation of a shared history of resistance and service, these communities developed a distinct collective identity that eventually eclipsed their diverse origins and which is today recognized as a distinct ethnicity.[35]

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[32] Colin Imber, *The Ottoman Empire: 1300 - 1650: The Structure of Power*, Third edition (Red Globe Press, 2019).

[33] Jane Hathaway, *The Politics of Households in Ottoman Egypt: The Rise of the Qazdağlis*, Cambridge Studies in Islamic Civilization (Cambridge University Press, 1997).

[34] William W. Fitzhugh, ed., *Vikings: The North Atlantic Saga*, Nachdr. (Smithsonian Books, 2000).

[35] Paul R. Magocsi, *A History of Ukraine: The Land and Its Peoples*, 2nd, rev.expanded ed edn (University of Toronto Press, 2010); Zenon Ė. Kohut, *The Making of Cossack Ukraine: Political Thought, Culture, and Identity Formation, 1569-1714* (McGill-Queen's University Press, 2025).

These parallels underscore how functional, professional, or social categories can, over time, solidify into enduring group identities. Just as the Janissaries, Mamluks, Vikings, and Cossacks illustrate, the process observed for the Peleset and Tjeker in the New Kingdom reflects a broader historical phenomenon in which initially fluid, practice-based communities can gradually acquire stable collective identities.

These examples collectively show that Egyptian New Kingdom sources often framed identity through geopolitical, social, and professional criteria rather than ethnicity. Groups could be defined by political allegiance, geographic association, social function, or military role, with fluidity allowing for mobility, assimilation, or territorialization over time. In this sense, what modern observers might be tempted to interpret as ethnic categories often actually reflected administrative, ideological, and functional distinctions projected by the Egyptian state onto the diverse Levantine world.

More in general, taken together, the evidence from the New Kingdom suggests that geopolitical and identitarian borders were not separate analytical categories but deeply intertwined dimensions of the same historical reality. In the Late Bronze Age Levant, political sovereignty, tributary networks, and imperial spheres of influence did not merely structure territory; they shaped the very framework through which people could be named, classified, and rendered intelligible. To be "of Tunip," "of Hatti," or affiliated with any recognized polity was to occupy a position within a geopolitical grid that conferred both intelligibility and a form of political personhood. Geographical and geopolitical realities and borders thus operated as powerful classificatory frames, providing the Egyptians with the primary criteria through which foreign populations were identified, ordered, and incorporated into diplomatic, military, and historical discourses.

At the same time, these borders functioned as social thresholds of inclusion and exclusion. Individuals and groups that could be mapped onto recognized sociopolitical entities, such as city-states, kingdoms, or imperial provinces, were integrated into a structured world of kingship, tribute, and treaty obligations. Those who could not, such as mobile groups, displaced persons, or marginal communities, were relegated to alternative labels that signalled their liminality, instability, or functional role, including outcasts like the Hapiru, "wanderers" like the *šꜣs.w* or bands of warriors and maritime raiders like the Sea People groups. In this way, geopolitical borders did more than separate territories; they established a hierarchy of social visibility, distinguishing actors embedded within the interstate system from those existing at its margins.

Political realignments could recast identities, as exemplified by the transformation of Tunip into "Tunip of Hatti," while the stabilization of marginal or professional groups could generate new, territorially anchored collectivities. Geopolitical borders shaped the conditions under which collective identities crystallized, evolved, or dissolved. Conversely, once such identities solidified, whether as military communities, settled coastal populations, or provincial subjects, they could themselves reinforce and consolidate new political geographies. The relationship between borders and identity was therefore reciprocal and dynamic: geopolitical realities framed perceptions of human difference, while evolving forms of collective belonging, in turn, reconfigured the political landscape. In the New Kingdom world, borders were not merely lines delineating space; they were generative structures that simultaneously organized territory, power, and the social imagination of who belonged where and who did not.

3. Conclusions: Toward an archaeology of invisible borders

The present contribution aimed at demonstrating that while borders rarely appear as physical markers in the archaeological or textual record, they can still be discerned by deploying

systematic methodological approaches that search for patterns, regularities, and variations in the data. Specifically, each of the approaches presented here exploits a different facet of the intrinsically relational nature of boundary-making to reconstruct inherently invisible borders. Network analysis of administrative correspondence accesses the relational and functional dimensions of authority, revealing how geopolitical borders can be inferred from gradients of competence rather than from explicit territorial demarcations. Onomastic and linguistic analysis, focused on personal names, uncovers sociolinguistic landscapes that structured interaction without crystallizing into rigid frontiers. Discourse analysis of textual identity frames illuminates the conceptual logic through which the Egyptians classified foreign populations, while those situated outside recognized polities were marked with alternative, often functional or stereotypical labels.

At the same time, investigating invisible borders also demands a continuous and critical reassessment of the theoretical premises underlying the analysis. In particular, the social borders that modern scholars might instinctively seek are not necessarily the boundaries that structured the lived experience in the Late Bronze Age, especially when they intersect with culturally constructed realities such as collective identities. Before attempting to locate these borders, it is thus essential first to understand how the societies under study conceptualized the realities we are investigating. For example, before looking for borders between ethnic groups, we should first determine whether ethnicity was truly a crucial element in defining collective identities in the first place. If it was not, what frameworks or categories were in use? In other words, our own categories, along with the cultural borders and border-creating realities that define them, need to be questioned and deconstructed before we can approach ancient societies in ways that might reveal the categories and boundaries truly significant to them.

We as scholars approaching these questions must therefore operate with dual awareness. We must try to reconstruct the historically situated boundaries that organized ancient societies while simultaneously interrogating the conceptual frameworks through which we attempt that reconstruction. By embracing indirect proxies, multimodal analyses, and quantitative approaches built on networks, clusters, and distributions, we can move toward an "archaeology of the invisible", one attentive not only to material remains but also to the intangible structures that shaped political and socio-cultural realities. This naturally applies also to borders, which, though often elusive or invisible, are neither inaccessible nor beyond scholarly inquiry.

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